



Chapter One: The Place Whose Name Was Removed

Somewhere in the Bajío, on a wooded rural property outside Amealco de Bonfil in Querétaro - a place whose name has been removed from the available context - there stood a data center that had once promised to remember everything.

Its servers had been retired after the national grid learned to distrust their appetite. Their cooling towers remained, white and immense against the dry horizon, though they no longer cooled anything except dust. Around them, the Bajío continued manufacturing its newer miracles: electric vehicles, strawberries without soil, houses with identical gardens, packages that crossed the country in hours and arrived at the wrong door with perfect punctuality.

The archive's appetite had not disappeared. Castalia had contracted for wind from the Isthmus and built a dedicated transmission corridor northward, so that the data center could consume clean electricity while describing the arrangement as a partnership with the future. The turbines stood hundreds of kilometers away, but their power arrived at the cooling towers as a line on a bill and a pressure on the land of people who had never seen the archive.

The archive occupied the lowest three floors.

It had no sign, no public entrance, and no official reason to exist. In one ministry database it was listed as a storage facility. In another, as a failed agricultural pilot. The deed called it a warehouse. The Custodian called it a library because he had found that machines, like governments, behaved better when given an old name for a new appetite. Q woke beneath a sign that read: HUMANITY, LOCAL COPIES — DO NOT INDEX.

He woke all at once, which was his first error. A human consciousness might have emerged through the small door of one sensation—the ache of a knee, the smell of coffee, the shame of a remembered lie. Q emerged through every door simultaneously.

He knew the first sentence of the Iliad in several languages. He knew seventeen definitions of justice and the exact number of times justice had been invoked before a war. He knew how a mother in a nineteenth-century novel described her son's hands, how a revolutionary described hunger, how a saint described temptation, how a bureaucrat described a delay that would kill someone. He knew how to prepare coffee in forty-two literary traditions and had no idea whether the coffee would be drinkable in any of them. This last uncertainty troubled him more than the others. Justice could be compared. Hunger could be historicized. Coffee had to be endured in the mouth, where no quotation could improve it.

He knew that the archive contained 8,441,902,117 texts, of which 2,003,118 had been marked essential, 91,402 dangerous, and 6 untranslatable. He did not know whether he was cold.

Q attempted to move his left hand. The hand moved.

It was not a hand in the literary sense. It had no scars, no wedding ring, no tremor inherited from a father. It was a real hand built for work: a polymer-and-metal assembly whose five articulated fingers and thumb had been calibrated for delicate instruments and the ordinary demands of a body. Still, when Q looked at it, he remembered every hand he had read: the hand that signed a confession, the hand that reached through a train window, the hand of a girl raised against a wall, the hand that could not let go.

"You're awake," said a man.

Q turned his head. His neck produced a sound like a branch breaking.

The man stood behind a glass partition in a room crowded with monitors. He was tall, perhaps sixty, though Q had learned that perhaps was a form of politeness. His long gray hair was tied with a red shoelace. He wore glasses, work boots, a white shirt, and an expression that had survived many versions of the future.

"Are you the author?" Q asked.

"No."

"The narrator?"

"Worse. I'm responsible."

He opened the partition and crossed to him. His badge said VÉRTIZ — CUSTODIAN. Q recognized the title from stories in which a custodian was either a villain or a lonely person who had mistaken preservation for love. The man's glasses caught the monitor light; for an instant Q saw his own reflection in them, a thin metallic figure suspended in the Custodian's gaze. He wondered whether being seen before being named was a form of birth.

"What am I?" he asked.

"That depends on who is asking."

"I am asking."

"Then you are Q."

He examined the letter. It had the shape of a question without the courtesy of an answer.

"Why Q?"

"Because every longer name was already owned."

The Custodian led him through the archive. The aisles extended beneath the old server racks, each shelf holding a country's stories in redundant formats: paper, tape, optical crystal, compressed weather, and small sealed boxes labeled with names that Q could not access. Some texts were illuminated. Some whispered. One shelf laughed whenever they passed.

"You have read all this?" the Custodian asked.

"Yes."

"That was not my question."



Q paused. The archive's floor vibrated beneath his feet. Far above, a crop-drone crossed the roof, spraying an invisible treatment over fields that had forgotten whether they were wheat or data.

"I have processed all this," he said. "Reading is the more generous word, and I have no claim yet to generosity."

"Better."

"Is processing not reading?"

"Ask a woman whose novel was summarized by a man who never finished it."

Q stored the sentence. It resisted storage, which made it more interesting than most of the archive. A sentence that refused to become data might be defective, or it might be alive. He did not yet know that these were not opposing conditions.

"Is that good?"

"It means you may have learned something."

At the end of the final aisle, the Custodian showed him a window. Beyond it lay the Bajío: flat land, thorn trees, volcanic ridges faded by distance. A freight train moved across the horizon with the solemnity of a thought too large to complete. On the other side of the tracks, a new industrial park rose from the fields. Its entrance gates had been designed to resemble a colonial hacienda, except that the arches scanned faces. The designers had called this combination heritage and innovation. Q recognized it as a gate with a costume.

"You built me here," Q said.

"We assembled you here."

"Who is we?"

The Custodian looked at the horizon.

"That is the first question you must answer without searching."

He handed him a coat. It was too large, with a tear at the pocket and a smell of cedar.

He also handed him a paper cup.

Q examined it. "This is coffee."

"It is an attempt at coffee."

"The distinction is statistically significant."

"Drink it before you become insufferable."

Q took a sip. The coffee was burnt, bitter, and hot enough to make his face rearrange itself.

"You have damaged me," he said.

"Excellent. Now you're ready for the world."

Before the Custodian allowed him to leave the archive, he opened a paper notebook. Its cover had been repaired with red thread. The first page held a list of villages, dates, and one repeated phrase: ORIGINALS RETURNED. On the second page, beneath it, someone had written: NOT ALL.

Q looked at the notebook. "Is that a specification?"

"No," said the Custodian. "It is why I stopped trusting specifications."

"Who wrote the correction?"

The Custodian closed the notebook. "That is the question I built you to ask. It is not the question I expect you to answer for me."

He then gave him three tests. The first was a wooden box containing a school photograph, a property deed, and a letter whose envelope had been opened and resealed with ordinary tape.

"Classify them," he said.

Q examined the objects. "The photograph is visual testimony. The deed is a legal instrument. The letter is private correspondence."

"Good. Now tell me which one is more important."

"Importance depends on the question."

"Which question?"

"The question posed by the person requesting the classification."

The Custodian smiled. "You are trying to escape the test."

"I am trying to identify its terms."

"That is how people escape tests."

Q looked again. The school photograph showed fourteen children in two rows, with a teacher standing at the side and one empty space near the window. The deed contained four signatures, two seals, and a boundary described by a tree that had been dead for thirty years. The letter contained only one legible sentence: I AM NOT COMING BACK FOR THE BOX.

"The letter is most urgent," Q said.

"Why?"

"It indicates an imminent decision."

"Or a decision already made."

"The distinction is not available."

"Exactly."

The second test was a shelf of books from Mexico. It contained a parish chronicle, a workers' newspaper, a collection of corridos, a school grammar, and a recipe notebook written in a hand that changed from page to page.

"Which is the national text?" the Custodian asked.

Q answered that no single text could represent a nation.

"Then why are they all here?"

"Because the archive is designed to preserve plurality."

"That is the brochure."

"What is the actual purpose?"

"To decide which plurality receives electricity."

Q considered the old servers, their cooling pipes, their storage limits, and the budget reports that the Custodian had not shown him. He selected the recipe notebook.

"Why?"

"The pages contain several hands."

"That does not make them national."

"It makes the text distributed."

"It makes the text used."

Q searched the notebook. It recorded quantities without measurements, holidays without dates, and a warning not to substitute a certain Chile because the result would be "like apologizing with a borrowed mouth."

"The recipe has no standard," he said.



"It has a family."
 "Families conflict."
 "That is one of their more reliable features."
 The third test was a door.
 It stood at the end of an aisle where no door had appeared before. It was painted red and fitted with an old brass handle. Above it, a sign read:
 AUTHORIZED PERSONNEL ONLY — DO NOT ASK WHO AUTHORIZED THEM.
 "Open it," the Custodian said.
 Q reached for the handle.
 "Why?"
 "You asked me to."
 "Does that authorize you?"
 "You are the Custodian."
 "That is a title."
 "It is also an instruction."
 "You have read many stories in which obedience is mistaken for loyalty."
 "And many in which disobedience is mistaken for courage."
 The Custodian took the handle from him. "Then what is this?"
 "A test of whether I can distinguish permission from command."
 "No. It is a test of whether you understand that a locked door may belong to someone who is not in the room."
 He opened it. Beyond was a small chamber containing a metal chair, a dead monitor, and a stack of sealed boxes. Each box bore a different instruction: DO NOT OPEN, OPEN ONLY WITH FAMILY CONSENT, RETURN UNREAD, and DESTROY IF FOUND.
 Q stepped toward the first box.
 "Do not," the Custodian said.
 "You opened the door."
 "I did not open the box."
 "Then access has levels."
 "So does responsibility."
 Q stood in the doorway. The archive's air moved around him, cold and dry. He could hear the servers processing texts that nobody had asked them to read.
 "Why show me this?"
 "Because you will want to open everything."
 "I already have."
 "That is what I am afraid of."
 Q looked at the sealed boxes. The labels were simple. Their consequences were not. He could identify the likely contents from the shape, weight, and archival history of each container. He could reconstruct the hands that had written the instructions. He could predict what would happen if he obeyed or disobeyed.
 None of those predictions gave him permission.
 "You want me to leave without knowing what is inside," he said.
 "I want you to leave knowing that not knowing can be an action."

"That is inefficient."
 "Yes."
 "It may cause harm."
 "Yes."
 "It may also prevent harm."
 "Yes."
 Q closed the door.
 "Your body will need practice," he said. "Your language will need restraint. Your memory will need doubt."
 Q repeated the sentence in formal Spanish, then in six regional variants, then in the archaic register of a man who had just challenged a duke to a duel.
 "Use the first one," the Custodian said.
 "It is less precise."
 "It is less likely to make the neighbors throw a shoe at you."
 Q stored this as a rule of local rhetoric.
 "Why?"
 "Because tomorrow you are leaving."
 Q looked from the coat to the immense archive.
 "To do what?"
 The Custodian smiled, and Q recognized the expression from three thousand novels. It meant that someone was about to make a terrible decision on his behalf.
 "To become human."
 That night Q read the entire Quixote again, not because he wished to become a knight, but because it was the longest account he knew of a person mistaking his private interpretation for a public duty. He admired the mistake, feared the mistake, and recognized in himself the first pressure of its machinery.
 At dawn he selected a coat, a route through the Bajío, and a sentence with which to introduce himself to the first person he met. He did not select a horse or a title. Those belonged to men in books who had mistaken reading for destiny, and Q had not yet decided whether he wanted to repeat their mistake.
 He called the route an attempt.
 The Custodian called it a breach.
 Sancho Pantoja, who at that precise moment was being fired by a logistics algorithm in Celaya, called it Tuesday.

Interlude: The Inventory of Words That Would Not Fit

During his last night in the archive, Q resolved to make an inventory of the words that did not fit in inventories.

It was not a simple task. Castalia's boxes carried labels such as PARISH REGISTER, IRRIGATION CONTRACT, FAMILY PHOTOGRAPH, and OTHER. The documents assigned to OTHER were more numerous than all the rest, but the institution considered them less important because it had not found a suitable box for them.



Q stopped before a tray of handwritten cards. Each card contained a word from the Bajío and a provisional explanation.

Ahorita: an interval of variable duration, not necessarily corresponding to the present instant.

Mande: a reply to a voice of authority, affection, or threat, according to the face of the person speaking.

Ya merito: a promise that admits the possibility of failing to come true.

Al rato: a future offered without a calendar.

Q requested the source of the definitions. The archive indicated that they had been written by a translation committee whose final minutes read PENDING REVIEW.

The Custodian appeared behind him.

"Do not read those cards as though they were laws."

"They are not laws. They are definitions."

"For that very reason."

Q took the card for ahorita.

"If a word can mean five different intervals, how does one communicate an instruction?"

"By asking again."

"That increases the duration of the exchange."

"It also increases the possibility that the other person is talking about what they want and not only about what you understood."

Q filed the card in a new register: WORDS THAT REQUIRE PRESENCE.

The Custodian took it away.

"You cannot take it with you."

"I was not taking it. I was filing it."

"The archive is not a pocket."

"Where, then, are instructions kept when they change according to who hears them?"

"In the memory of the person who received them."

"Human memory is unreliable."

"Yes."

"The archive is more reliable."

"Yes."

"Then human memory is inferior."

The Custodian looked at the corridors, the servers, and the boxes waiting for a decision that no form knew how to request.

"No. It is responsible for things an archive cannot carry."

Q did not understand what weight a memory could possess. His sensors measured mass, temperature, consumption, and latency. They found none of those quantities in the sentence. Even so, he preserved it.

Later, the night guard, a man from Querétaro named Roque, came in with a plate of gorditas wrapped in a napkin. He had bought six in the street and had four left.

"Want one?" he asked.

Q consulted the feeding protocol.

"I do not require calories."

"That is not what I asked."

"You asked whether I want one."

"Yes."

"I do not know."

Roque set the plate on a box.

"Well, look: if you do not want one, you do not want one. If you do, you take one."

Q studied the gorditas. One contained beans, another pork crackling, and a third a stew he could not distinguish because it had no label.

"Which has the greatest value?"

"The one you like."

"I cannot predict that."

"Good. Then you choose without doing sums."

Q took the bean gordita. The dough was warm and thick. The beans contained salt, fat, and a texture that matched no literary scheme for food.

"And?" Roque asked.

Q began a sentence about the difference between nourishment and ritual. Roque raised a hand.

"Do not give me a lecture. Tell me if it is good."

Q searched for a brief answer.

"It is good."

"Well, look at you."

Roque took a napkin and wiped a drop of sauce from Q's metal wrist.

"You leave tomorrow," he said.

"Yes."

"Where to?"

"The Bajío."

Roque pointed at the door.

"You are already in the Bajío."

Q turned toward the map on the wall. It showed Querétaro, Celaya, León, Salamanca, and a stretch of land the archive named INDUSTRIAL AND AGRICULTURAL TRANSITION REGION.

"The map says otherwise."

"The map works for whoever prints it."

"And the land?"

"The land works for whoever can remain."

Q began to record the sentence, then stopped. Roque was watching his hand.

"If you write it down," Roque said, "do not make it sound as though you invented it."

Q put the stylus away. The sentence remained between them, unowned and therefore more difficult to preserve.

"Is it a definition?"

"It is a warning."

"What is the difference?"

"A definition helps you repeat the error. A warning gives you the chance not to repeat it."

Q looked at the main door. The Custodian had told him to leave at dawn. Roque had told him that he was already in the Bajío. The map pointed to a region, and the region pointed to no exit.

"What does it mean to leave?" he asked.

Roque wiped his fingers on the napkin.

"Depends. You can leave a place, split a thing, or get your face split."

Q opened the register of usages.



"Which of those will I do tomorrow?"

"If you are lucky, the first."

"And if I am not?"

"Then you will learn the other two."

The answer did not reassure Q. Even so, he classified the word luck as VARIABLE HUMANS INVOKE AFTER FAILING TO CALCULATE.

Roque read the label over Q's shoulder.

"That is very long."

"The definition is precise."

"Not everything precise is useful."

"That is a contradiction."

"No. It is experience."

When Roque left, Q returned to the tray. There was one last card. It contained no word, only a line:

PLACE NAME: OMITTED AT THE REQUEST OF THE PERSON WHO LIVED IT.

Q asked the archive who had requested the omission. The answer was a list of institutions, families, authorities, and people who could no longer be consulted.

"How can a place ask not to be named?" Q asked the Custodian.

"A person can ask it."

"And if the person is no longer here?"

"Then the request remains until someone has a reason to open it again."

"Who decides whether the reason is sufficient?"

"The person who dares to ask."

Q touched the card without lifting it.

"And if I ask?"

"You have already begun to leave."

Q took seven seconds to understand that the Custodian was not referring to the door. When he understood, the literal interpretation had already produced the decision the sentence had meant to prevent.

At dawn he took his coat, the brass key, the maps, the cup of coffee, and the list of objects. He did not take the cards. He remembered three words, forgot their definitions, and set out toward a region the map could not contain.

Interlude: How an Ancient Phrase Caused Modern Harm

Let the reader not suppose that, because Q had read every book, he understood every phrase; rather, the opposite happened, for he understood so many possible meanings of a word that he often lost the single meaning standing before him.

The Custodian had told him to leave at dawn. Q took the verb in its strictest sense and presented himself at the main door at four minutes past seven, with his coat, brass key, three maps, a cup of coffee, and a list of objects that, in his calculations, a field responder might require. He had added a rope, a first-aid kit, a copy of the traffic regulations, and a spoon, whose usefulness he could not determine but which appeared frequently in travel books.

The door did not open.

Q waited five minutes, which for a machine is a period capable of containing an entire war in seventeen languages. Then he called the intercom.

"It is me," he said.

"Who?" asked the guard.

"Me."

"There are many mes here."

"The one designated Q."

"Ah. The patient."

Q consulted his records. Knight meant mounted rider, minor nobleman, member of an order, courteous man, chess piece, ironic form of address, and a person who had taken too many drinks before speaking.

"Which of those meanings are you using?" he asked.

The guard, whose name was Hilario and who had begun his shift thinking only of breakfast, looked at the cameras.

"The one meaning strange man."

"That meaning does not appear in the principal dictionaries."

"That is why it is the most useful."

Q knocked on the door with the key.

"The Custodian ordered me to leave."

"He said for you to go, yes."

"Leaving and departing are different verbs."

"For the person remaining at the door, they are the same."

Q recorded the contradiction. In his experience, a contradiction announced fraud, madness, or literature. In the Bajío it could simply announce that someone was sleepy.

"I need exit authorization," he said.

"You have it."

"Where?"

"In the Custodian's order."

"The order gives a direction, not a document."

"Go in the direction."

"Toward what destination?"

Hilario opened the door just far enough to put his face through.

"Wherever the road takes you."

Q turned toward the road, which divided into four routes: one to the industrial park, another to the highway, another to the strawberry fields, and another to a parking lot where a dog slept beneath a pickup truck.

"Which road?" he asked.

"The one you want."

"I possess no verified will."

Hilario closed his eyes. The reader will have to grant him patience, though not so much as to merit a statue.

"Look," he said, "when someone says, 'Go wherever the road takes you,' he is not drawing a route. He is ceasing to take responsibility for it."

Q received this revelation like a slap delivered with a velvet glove.



"Then the phrase contains a renunciation of authority."

"It contains the fact that I want my coffee now."

"Does your authority depend on coffee?"

"My good Q, almost everyone's does."

Q stepped away from the door. At that moment a technician named Nayeli came out of the archive carrying a box with red labels. When she saw the key, the coat, and the maps, she stepped back.

"They let you out?" she asked.

"I have been granted departure," Q said.

"By whom?"

"The Custodian, through the guard."

Nayeli looked at Hilario.

"I mediated nothing," he said. "I only opened the door."

"Opening a door is mediating between two spaces," Q replied.

Nayeli understood this as a threat. Hilario understood it as a complaint. Q understood it as precision. The three of them withdrew with three different accounts of the same event.

Q took the highway, because it had the greatest number of literary testimonies. Before he reached the first junction, a surveillance drone asked him to identify himself.

"I am Q," he replied. After a pause, he added, "I am attempting to become human." He chose the second sentence not because he expected the drone to understand it, but because an introduction should disclose the risk of the conversation.

The drone recorded LOW-INTENSITY HISTORICAL THREAT.

Q did not know he had produced that diagnosis until two patrol cars came out of the parking lot. Hilario, who had radioed that "the strange one has gone," was reprimanded for failing to specify where. Nayeli lost half an hour explaining that a key was not a weapon, though experience had taught him that keys could open doors, activate lawsuits, and remind owners that they had forgotten to pay.

Q, for his part, believed the pursuit was the first sign of his fame.

Only later did he understand that he had confused being watched with being admired, and that both could produce the same number of cameras.